

Stereotypes

What Are Stereotypes?

Stereotypes are oversimplified beliefs or assumptions about a group of people based on characteristics like gender, age, occupation, or region. They often ignore individual differences and can lead to unfair judgments.

- People who wear glasses must be smart.
- Tall people must be good at basketball.
- Cat people are quiet; dog people are outgoing.
- Left-handed people are more creative.
- Only children are spoiled.

Is there a good stereotype?

For example:

- "Asians are good at math."
- "Teachers are nurturing."
- "Nurses are patient and caring."
- "French people are romantic."
- "Women are better listeners."

Personal Reflection: A Stereotype That Wasn't True

Think of a stereotype you once believed, like "Everyone from Sichuan eats spicy food."

- I used to think programmers are all quiet and bad at small talk, but my cousin joined a tech company last year and now he never stops talking at family dinners.
- I used to think people over 50 can't learn new technology, but my mom learned to pay with her phone, call a ride, and post short videos — all in one year.
- I used to think only children are spoiled and selfish, until I met my friend Liu, an only child who cooks for his parents every weekend.

Different types of stereotypes

- Gender
 - Family roles: Men are usually the providers; women are usually the caregivers.
 - Personality: Women are more emotional; men are more rational.
 - Hobbies: Football is for boys; dancing is for girls.
 - Behavior: Boys don't cry.
 - Skills and abilities: Men are better at math and driving; women are better at languages.
 - Occupations: Nurses and kindergarten teachers are mostly women.
- Age
 - Seniors: Seniors can't use smartphones.
 - Teenagers: Teenagers are lazy and only play games.
 - Kids: Kids are honest and innocent.
- Occupation
 - Teachers: Teachers are patient and love to talk.
 - Doctors: Doctors are cold and always in a hurry.
- Region
 - North: Northerners are tall and good at drinking.
 - South: Southerners are good at doing business.
 - Certain provinces: People from Sichuan all eat spicy food.
 - Certain countries: French people are romantic.
- Brands
 - People who buy Pop Mart blind boxes love surprises.
 - Moutai is for business dinners, not casual meals.
 - People who shop at Sam's Club always buy in bulk.

Personality typing systems

- MBTI
- Blood Type
- Horoscope

Where did we get the stereotypes?

- Media: Movies, TV, and short videos repeat the same picture — scientists are always nerdy guys with glasses, and the boss in every short drama is cold, rich, and never smiles.
- School and teachers: Textbooks and teachers oversimplify — "people in rich countries all live easy lives" or "students from poor families study harder."
- People around us: Family and friends repeat them — aunts at family dinners say a woman who isn't married by 30 must be too picky.
- Our own brain: We take shortcuts — putting people in boxes is easier than getting to know every single person.

How do we resolve this issue?